

Suta's Biswas says that digital technology has been a boon for brands like hers to keep their product lifecycle sustainable. Suta Earth—an initiative run by her company—makes bags out of torn/stained sarees that would have otherwise ended up in a landfill. Another initiative of the company is of reselling products, where customers can resell Suta products at around 80 per cent of the MRP, and all this is managed through the company's digital presence. "Digital channels like Instagram and Facebook are very important. We started as a Facebook page. The cost of acquisition of a customer is much lower when it happens via a digital medium," she says.

DESPITE THESE initiatives and resolutions, the fashion industry remains one of the most polluting across sectors and geographies. A 2017 Changing Markets Foundation investigation found that factories in Indonesia, China and India were dumping highly toxic wastewater into local waterways, destroying marine life, and exposing workers and the local population to harmful chemicals. It further revealed the links between polluting factories and major fashion brands including H&M, Zara/Inditex, ASOS, Levi's, Tesco and UCB, among others.

Not much has changed with respect to the polluting tendencies of the fashion industry since then. According to the Business of Fashion-McKinsey State of Fashion 2022 report, the industry accounts for approximately 2.1 billion tonnes of CO₂ emissions per year—that's 4 per cent of annual global emissions. More than 70 per cent of these emissions come from production processes, with the remainder coming from retail, logistics and product use. Some 125 compa-

FOCUS ON SUSTAINABILITY

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More than 300 international fashion brands are expected to open their stores in India by 2022-23

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The global fashion industry is the second-biggest consumer of water, according to the UN Environment Programme

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Following the popularity of niche sustainable brands, mass-market brands like Zara and H&M have also started to undertake sustainable measures

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Some sustainable measures include selection of natural and non-animal-based fabrics, digital printing, and sustainable dyeing methods

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India has a unique advantage when it comes to sustainable clothing adaptability due to its historical and cultural practices

nies—including brands like Levi's and H&M—have committed to net-zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2050 through the UN Fashion Industry Charter for Climate Action launched in 2018, the report states. "Most public commitments made by fashion brands in the run-up to COP26 were to reduce emissions by 30 per cent by 2030 (from 2015 levels or later). Some companies, such as Levi Strauss & Co., have committed to reducing emissions across their supply chain by 40 per cent by 2025, while others, such as H&M, are striving to be 'climate positive', reducing more greenhouse gas emissions than its value chain emits, by 2040," the report adds.

Surrounded by such challenges, companies in India are trying to lead the way but it's an uphill battle with a dearth of funds, experts say. In 2017, only 1-2 per cent of investments in climate adaptation projects for textile manufacturing came from the private sector globally. This number needs to grow 10 times by 2030 for developing countries alone. Despite India being among the top five apparel markets, and a global hub of manufacturing fast-fashion garments that are exported to Europe and the US, it's the bigger brands that need to take the initiative and make some real impact, experts add.

They also say that India has a unique advantage when it comes to sustainable clothing adaptability due to its historical and cultural practices. Among the key reasons that they point towards, to explain the growth of sustainable clothing in India, is its position as a big hub for production of apparel and textiles, which brings in a lot of learnings and standards from other markets. And from a demand standpoint, the fact that natural fibres always had a market—and cultural conditioning—is a huge driver. **BT**

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